

Word stress

When a word has more than one syllable, one of the syllables is always louder than the others in spoken English—this is the syllable that is stressed.

Rule 1

In many English words, the stress is on the first syllable.

dam-age

Rule 2

A word with a prefix or suffix usually has the stress on the root word.

in-ter-rup-tion

Rule 3

In words beginning with de-, re-, in-, po-, pro-, or a- the first syllable is usually not stressed.

pro-gres-sive

Rule 4

Two vowels together in the last syllable often indicate a stressed last syllable.

sus-tain

Rule 5

A word with a double consonant in the middle puts stress on the syllable before the consonant.

mid-dle

Rule 6

The stress is usually on the syllable preceding the suffixes -tion, -ity, -ic, -ical, -ian, -ial, and -ious.

im-i-ta-tion

Rule 7

The stress is usually on the second syllable before the suffix -ate.

o-rig-i-nate

Rule 8

If none of 1–7 apply, in words with three or more syllables, one of the first two syllables is usually stressed.

sym-pho-ny

Iambic pentameter

Syllables are often used in literature to give sentences a lilting rhythm and to emphasize certain parts of a word. A poetic form called iambic pentameter consists of ten syllables in each line. The ten syllables are divided into five pairs of alternating unstressed and stressed syllables. The rhythm in each line resembles the “da-DUM” sound of a heartbeat.

The only English letter whose name has more than one syllable is **w**, which is pronounced “**duh-bull-you.**”

▷ Shakespearean syllables

Many people have used this technique, including the English playwright William Shakespeare (1564–1616). This famous line is taken from his tragedy *Macbeth*.

Is this - a dag - ger I - see be - fore me

The first syllable in a pair is unstressed and represents the quieter “da” in the heartbeat rhythm.

The second syllable in the pair is stressed and represents the louder “DUM” in the heartbeat rhythm.